



Tataskweyak Cree Nation

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The Honorable Adrien Sala
Minister responsible for Manitoba Hydro
Government of Manitoba

Allan Danroth
President & Chief Executive Officer
Manitoba Hydro

December 3, 2025

Via email

Dear Minister Sala and Mr. Danroth:

Re: Request for Urgent Action to Protect Sturgeon

As Chief of Tataskweyak Cree Nation (TCN), I write on behalf of my Nation, its citizens and *namao* (sturgeon) regarding Manitoba Hydro's October 30, 2025 *Notice of Operating Plan Forecast- Missi Falls*.

For the reasons set out below, we request Manitoba Hydro amend the forecasted operating plan for Missi Falls for December 2025 into the new year to ensure a flow rate sufficient to safeguard overwintering habitat for sturgeon on the Lower Churchill River.

Background

For TCN, the Churchill River is not only a source of water, but a living entity deeply embedded in our cultural identity, traditional practices and community well-being. The river once supported multiple thriving sturgeon populations. Elders share stories of the abundance of sturgeon all along the Churchill River – an important food source and the focus of many spiritual and cultural stories, songs, practices.

In 1973, Manitoba Hydro began construction on the Churchill River Diversion (CRD) – a system of channels, dams and control structures that can divert up to 98.5% of the Churchill River's flow into the Nelson River by controlling the flow out of Missi Falls control structure at the outlet of South Indian Lake.

Since it began operations over four decades ago, the licensing and operation of the CRD project has had devastating impacts on sturgeon populations on the Lower Churchill River, and on TCN's Treaty rights and way of life. Now, only one remnant population exists at the mouth of the Little Churchill River.

Flow Regime Report

Experts commissioned by TCN recently completed a report entitled *The Impacts of the Churchill River Diversion in the Lower Churchill River*. The report, which was carried out with funding from TCN and the Department of Fisheries and Oceans Canada, integrates traditional knowledge, science based studies and hydraulic monitoring to conclude that the CRD has led to the collapse of sturgeon populations by (i) diverting over 90% of the river's flow for extended periods, and in turn drastically reducing available sturgeon habitat; and (ii) punctuating these flows with abrupt and irregular surges, thereby creating a highly unpredictable hydrological environment to which the downstream ecosystem cannot adapt.

The report affirms that in the winter, water flows below 4,000 cubic feet per second (cfs) drastically increase the risk of the river freezing to its bottom, causing the loss of overwintering habitat and widespread mortality of sturgeon. This finding is consistent with reports from TCN members who report finding ice without water underneath it all along the Churchill River downstream of Missi Falls during winter months each year.

The 2025 Forecast

We understand from the October 30th update that Missi Falls is forecasted to release outflow at 4,250 cfs throughout November 2025, where it will then decrease to 3,250 cfs on December 10 and into the new year.

We are deeply concerned that the approach set out in the 2025 Forecast will result in the river once again freezing to its bed. This could have serious, long-term consequences for remaining sturgeon on the Lower Churchill River, as well as for TCN's ability to exercise our Treaty right to fish and to fulfil our role as the traditional stewards of our lands and waters.

Conclusion

In light of the above, we urgently request Manitoba Hydro amend its forecasted operating plan to increase flows through Missi Falls to ensure sturgeon will survive the winter and have suitable deep pools of water available under ice cover. Failing to do so would jeopardize the sturgeon that remain on the Lower Churchill. It would further be contrary to the spirit and intent of our Treaty relationship and the principles of reconciliation.

We look forward to Manitoba Hydro's confirmation that it will amend its forecasted operating plan to ensure the protection of sturgeon on the Lower Churchill.

Ekosi,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read "D. Spence", is centered on a light blue rectangular background.

Chief Doreen Spence

cc. The Honorable Joanne Thomson, Minister of Fisheries and Oceans Canada